

So Braucherei and Urglaawe are not synonymous?

No, though in some ways they are wrapped around one another. Braucherei has many unbroken roots in pre-Christian practices, but it also has layers from other cultures or traditions with which it came into contact. Braucherei, though, is not a religion; it is a health and healing practice. Urglaawe is the continuation of the pre-Christian faith as viewed within Pennsylvania German culture today. Urglaawe is a religion or a way of life.

Must one be of Pennsylvania German (Deutsch) descent to be a Braucher or an Urglaawer?

No to both. Braucherei is seen as a gift that can be embraced by all. However, the cultural context of Braucherei is that of the Deutsch nation, so a respect and understanding of our culture and our traditions is expected.

As for Urglaawe, it is neither our business nor our desire to question whom the gods and goddesses call and for what reason. As with Braucherei, Urglaawe's cultural context is Deutsch and a respect and understanding for our modes of living is expected. As long as our traditions and our form of the faith is respected, we welcome all to learn more.

So a person may be both a Braucher and an Urglaawer?

Absolutely. Since Braucherei is based in spirituality, it is available to all faiths, with one exception, and that is the lack of a spiritual faith. Urglaawer can practice Braucherei comfortably within a fully Heathen context, replacing Kabbalah with Runes and calling upon our deities or known spirits to aid us in the healing process.

As the body of lore is distributed, researched, and put into practice, the Urglaawe context of Braucherei will become more unified and gelled. We look forward to advancing this process.

What language is used in Braucherei and Urglaawe?

English and Deutsch are used in both Braucherei and Urglaawe. Making Deutsch resources readily available is a key task both for Brauchers and Urglaawer. The Deutsch content of chants, charms, and prayers is beautiful, and a working knowledge of the language can help practitioners to tap into the beauty (though perhaps guttural) of the meanings of the words.

Where may I learn more about Braucherei?

The Three Sisters Center for the Healing Arts holds regular Guild Gatherings for those interested in Braucherei. Additionally, the Center holds a full course on the history and background of the practice. The course is built upon interviews with over 80 practitioners and research into the origins and evolution of the practice's philosophies.

- Visit the website of Three Sisters Center for the Healing Arts at <http://www.threesisterscenter.com>
- Join the Braucherei Zunftsammlung / Braucherei Guild Gathering Meetup Group. The website is <http://www.meetup.com/braucherei>.
- Attend one of the Guild Gatherings. They are posted on both the Three Sister's site and the Meetup Group.
- Send an e-mail to thr3sisters@aol.com

How can I find out more about Urglaawe

- Visit <http://www.urglaawe.org> or our ceremony recap site at <http://urglaawe.ning.com>
- Send an e-mail to us at info@urglaawe.org
- Join our active Hexenkunst Yahoo Group at <http://groups.yahoo.com/group/hexenkunst>
- Write to us at the address on the front of this flyer.
- Attend one of our events. Many regional public events for Urglaawe and other Heathen communities are listed on the website of the Asatru and Urglaawe Meetup of Eastern Pennsylvania and NJ: <http://asatru.meetup.com/249/>

der Urglaawe



The Relationship between Urglaawe and Braucherei



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What is Braucherei?

Braucherei is the age-old heirloom healing practice that has been passed down through the centuries. The early Pennsylvania German settlers brought it with them on their migration to the Americas. Once here, the practice flourished until suppression by national medical organizations and the government took its toll on the practice. Fortunately, it never died out, and many younger people are embracing the traditions and practices of our forebears. We seek to honor and revive the spiritual, folk medical, and agricultural wisdom of the Pennsylvania German people. We are dedicated to returning this cultural inheritance in its most whole and inspired form to its heirs and their future generations. We recognize Pennsylvania German tradition and culture as a living being and seek to sustain and grow its spirit. We honor the traditions of Elders and remain open to the continuing evolution of traditional culture

What are the guiding principles of Braucherei?

We seek to revive the resourcefulness of the traditional Pennsylvania German culture. We see this resourcefulness as the key to a sustainable future. Traditional Pennsylvania German agriculture recognizes the interdependence of all of creation. We honor the respectful way in which this culture cares for the land and all of its creatures.

We honor the unique spiritual and cultural inheritance from which the Pennsylvania German healing traditions of Braucherei evolved. We are grateful to inherit a healing tradition, which honors and encompasses all of our history as a people and all of our ancestors.

We believe that this living being of culture and tradition must be continuously nurtured and allowed to evolve, recognizing that otherwise it would stagnate and die.

We believe that education and healing are vital to all people, and we are dedicated to making this folk tradition available and accessible to all of its heirs.

How do these principles differ from Urglaawe?

The guiding principles of Urglaawe and Braucherei are very similar. One key difference, though, is that Braucherei is considered to be a spiritual healing practice, not a religion. Urglaawe is a faith

Individuals of a variety of religious backgrounds can practice Braucherei. The tradition has been exposed to many different influences over the centuries, and individual practitioners have varied in their adoption of these influences. There is little-to-no doubt that some core features of Braucherei, particularly the ceremonies, are rooted in pre-Christian practice. These features are the aspects of Braucherei that Urglaawer treasure the most. Braucherei has passed along, mostly through oral tradition, lore and wisdom from the remote past that might otherwise be lost.

What are some examples of this preserved lore?

The nature of some of the chants of Braucherei is very similar in form to those of older Teutonic charms found in other parts of Europe. Research is still being conducted on some of the charms, particularly those that are used in Heathen form in the magical practice of Hexerei.

More obviously Heathen are the numerous references, and even ceremonies, that include honoring Holle, Wodan, and other deities and spirits of the land. Holle's importance is reflected in the Deutsch name for the elderberry: Hollerbeier or Hollebeer, which is regarded in Braucherei both as a healing plant and a vehicle for communicating with the spirit world.

Ceremonies and observances of Braucherei also reflect Heathen roots and are thus features of Urglaawe ceremonies and observances. For example, Groundhog Day, which seems like a goofy observance to most Americans, holds deep spiritual meaning for practitioners of Braucherei as well as for Urglaawer. Groundhog Day is the day that land spirits traveling with Holle on a Wild Hunt begin to return to the land from other realms. The groundhog represents these otherworldly travelers, and he brings news from these realms.

To us, his news is not merely the weather for the next six weeks. This is a good time for working with spirits and learning mysteries of the universe.

Groundhog Day has another layer of observance, too. As the spirits return to the land, they renew the soil and set the scene for the coming fertile times. At this time, we are to allow the fire in the hearth to burn out, and then we are to clean the hearth out completely and start a new fire with birch (sacred to Frigg) wood. We celebrate feminine creativity at this time.

Much as we clean out our hearth of old ashes, we also clear out the remnants of last year's harvest from our storage bins. The remnants are used to create the Butzemann, a scarecrow figure who is the father and protector of the coming year's crop. He is shown the land he is responsible for and given instructions on what to do, and then he is placed on the farm or in the garden. He will hang there until the time between the autumn equinox and Allelieweziel, during which he is to be burned.

And one other feature of Groundhog Day is our seasonal focus. At this time, we begin to lay the groundwork for fulfilling our New Year's resolutions. We set plans for achieving goals, and begin to map out our use of land, etc.

This is a lot for just one holiday, is it not? We are thankful that Braucherei kept these traditions alive.

Do all Brauchers engage in these practices?

No. As mentioned earlier, Braucherei is a spiritual healing practice, not a faith or religion. Thus, there is a full spectrum of spiritual paths among the practitioners of Braucherei. Most identify themselves as Christian. Many still recognize and will practice the non-Christian elements. Others will engage only in the Christian aspects of Braucherei. Urglaawer pursue the Heathen aspects of the practice. Braucherei is a large, complex practice. There is room for all paths. This is another difference between Urglaawe and Braucherei: Urglaawe is strictly Heathen.